



‘Aid’ to higher education in a multiplex world: Exploring the diversity of donor discourses and rationales

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ABSTRACT

The international development landscape is more ‘multiplex’ today than was the case after WWII, when the architecture of international aid was established. A broad range of national, international, multinational, and private organisations now operate within a more interdependent and participatory landscape. Attitudes to aid have also shifted significantly in recent years, due to international agreements around aid ‘effectiveness’ and global events. This article considers how this changing landscape has affected aid to higher education in lower-income contexts. Analysis of the main publicly-facing documents produced by the top 15 funders of higher education in the Global South reveals a significant discursive shift away from traditional understandings of ‘aid’, while also pointing to entrenched norms and hierarchies that persist, despite this rhetorical change. The findings offer a timely reflection on the roles assumed by funders of higher education in LMICs and on the position of higher education within broader development agendas around the world.

1. Introduction

The architecture of international aid established after the Second World War followed a dual (and some would say contradictory) logic. On the one hand, it emerged from a genuine desire for global justice and peace, to lay the foundations for a world in which all individuals could live in freedom and dignity, and nations could avoid conflict; on the other, it acted as a tool for foreign policy and national self-interest, whether veiled or explicit, with those countries injecting their own resources seeking returns and influence. Higher education is no exception in this regard. The wealthy countries and institutions of the Global North have for many decades provided support for the higher education systems of lower-income countries, as well as scholarships to individuals from those countries, as a means of building administrative and economic capacity. Yet these actions have had a clear strategic design, with the education of elites in the donor country’s universities, and close relations with domestic higher education systems, a key part of soft power, knowledge diplomacy and geopolitical influence¹ (Knight, 2022, 2023; Moscovitz and Sabzalieva, 2023).

Nevertheless, this contradictory equilibrium has been troubled in recent years through changes in the global order. The US hegemony, established in the mid-20th century and solidified through the collapse of the Soviet Union, while still in place, has been weakened by the emergence of new centres of power, most notably China, leading to a more multipolar world. Acharya (2017) points to three key factors of change: regionalism (the European Union being the most prominent example), the emergence of new powers (e.g. BRICS), and the rise of ‘global civil society’ and transnational movements. This ‘multiplex’ world contains multiple significant actors at play across national, regional, and supranational levels, including nation states, international, multinational, and regional governmental, non-governmental, and private organisations, within a more interdependent economic and political space. This multiplicity is certainly evident in the sphere of international aid, now characterised by a number of new bilateral donors (e.g. China, Türkiye, the Arabian Gulf states) and private foundations (e.g. Gates Foundation, MasterCard Foundation) in addition to the traditional Western and multilateral organisations.

Attitudes to aid have also shifted significantly in recent years, due

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¹ For an illustration, see US Secretary of State Antony Blinken’s opening address to 75th NAFSA: National Association of International Educators’ conference, June 2023.

both to international agreements around aid “effectiveness” and to global events. Mawdsley et al. (2018), for instance, have argued that, since the 2007–2008 financial crisis, although the quantity of aid has surprisingly not been reduced, there has been a qualitative shift away from the pro-poor focus of the 1990s towards ideas of ‘shared prosperity’ and explicit self-interest to bolster private sector trade, a phenomenon they refer to as “retroliberalism”. Interestingly, this change means that traditional donors are now acting more like newer Southern donors in blurring the lines between aid and trade/investment.

The question that arises is how this changing landscape has affected aid to higher education. Has it become correspondingly multiplex or is it still dominated by the traditional donors? And has the arrival of new actors shifted or simply reproduced the underpinning logic? This article aims to explore these questions through an analysis of the work of key donor agencies. Specifically, it focuses on four main questions: the rationales for supporting higher education, the roles assumed by donor agencies, how funding for higher education is conceptualised and what modalities of support are employed. Additionally, we ask how the concept of ‘aid’ has changed over time within the different types of donor organisations. We see this as an important aspect to understand, given that the conceptual approach to ‘aid’ may influence the rationales for practical decisions that actors make, the kinds of roles actors take, and the modalities of aid actors support and implement.

While there are extensive bodies of literature on aid generally, on the work of donor organisations, and to some extent on general education, research specifically on higher education is limited. There are some general overviews of aid to higher education (e.g. Buchert and King, 1995; Childs, 2015; Tilak, 2002; Varghese, 2010), advocating for the importance of the sector and pointing to problems of fragmentation, lack of attention to the countries in greatest need and the high proportion of aid dedicated to scholarships. There are some more focused studies on the work of specific development agencies (Koehn, 2013; Maldonado-Maldonado and Cantwell, 2009), and in particular assessments of World Bank programmes (e.g. Collins and Rhoads, 2010; Molla, 2014; Rapplee and Un, 2018). Some general treatments of international organisations have important ramifications for higher education, for example the in-depth study of knowledge-based aid in four development agencies (JICA, SIDA, DFID, and the World Bank) carried out by King and McGrath (2004). Furthermore, questions surrounding partnerships between higher education institutions have had increased attention in recent years (e.g. Obamba and Mwema, 2009; Samoff and Carrol, 2004; Schowengerdt, 2016; Smail, 2015).

The factual basis of aid flows to higher education has been significantly improved by the recent study by UNESCO-IESALC (Galán-Muros et al., 2022), which assessed the allocation of the funds in terms of recipients (highlighting that only 10 % of funds go to low-income countries), and type (with 71 % going to scholarships, largely in donor country systems). While highlighting some important trends, these data are subject to the limitations of the OECD Creditor Reporting System (CRS), which do not include ‘emerging’ donors such as China and raise a number of problematic questions of what does and does not count as higher education support (Rensimer and McCowan, 2023). Much remains to be known – particularly in terms of differentiation between actors, and the diversity of forms of engagement with higher education systems.

Understanding these questions of international support to higher education is crucial for those inside and outside the sector. First, higher education has (re)-assumed an important role in the discourse around development, after years of relative neglect, as evidenced by its inclusion as an explicit target in the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) (McCowan, 2019). Although external funding to higher education has been highly uneven – in terms of who/what receives support and where the funding comes from – its existence has been a feature of most higher education systems around the world and a prerequisite of the sector’s development in many less-resourced contexts. The geopolitical significance of higher education (Moscovitz and Sabzalieva, 2023) – and its

role in soft power and knowledge diplomacy – is intensifying, as is its economic role, being not only the primary mechanism for allocation of high-level employment, but also a significant site for corporate interests and profit-making in itself. Marginson (2024) shows how universities are being caught up in new geopolitical struggles, with the pro-internationalisation era of 1990–2010 being replaced by ‘nativism’ in science and student mobility in the Anglosphere.

Second, as discussed above, there are major changes at the global level influencing these processes that have not yet been fully understood. It is well documented that the aid landscape has shifted significantly over the past 20 years, as a result of international agreements around “aid effectiveness” (e.g. Paris, Busan) – with a growing emphasis on mutuality and partnership, as well as improved cooperation amongst donors. As outlined above, the global order is becoming more “multiplex” (Acharya, 2017), with a greater diversity of actors engaging in the landscape. In order to understand development support to higher education in this context, we must engage with the diversity in the sector and acknowledge that broad changes have a differential impact on individual donors – their rationales for supporting higher education, the modalities that they choose to support, and the ways in which they conceptualise their roles in the ecosystem.

Some clarifications on the scope of this article are needed. The aim here is only to look at the donor perspective on higher education support: naturally, there are a number of other dimensions to the phenomenon – in particular the perspectives of recipient countries, and other issues such as asymmetries of international partnerships. Furthermore, it was not possible in a study of this size to cover all forms of donor organisation: the close analysis was limited to major donors about which relevant information could be gathered (further details are given in the methods section below). As a result, it was not possible to cover important new actors such as China and India. Furthermore, in selecting types of donors for case studies, it is recognised that each has unique characteristics, and a proxy cannot stand for the whole category.

In addressing this topic, it is important also to acknowledge that higher education aid is just one influence on the development of global higher education policy and national systems, with the main influences arguably being marketisation on the one hand and the quest for world-class university status, underpinned by international rankings, on the other. Transnational corporations and direct foreign investment in for-profit higher education are another important piece in the puzzle of the development of the sector. Nevertheless, the influence of international organisations on lower-income countries heavily dependent on aid is significant, as are the more subtle influences on middle-income countries that occur through the mechanism of high numbers of their elites pursuing higher education in donor countries.

The section that follows will outline the research design and methods adopted in this study. Following that is an analysis of the data pertaining to the selected case studies, before implications are drawn out for the landscape of international higher education aid in contemporary times.

2. Methodology

Given the complex, multi-scalar higher education aid environment and the variety of actors within it, we elected in this study to analyse in-depth the primary actors that currently provide the greatest volume of funding to higher education systems and institutions based in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs).

Our methodological approach comprised two components: firstly, a mapping exercise to broadly explore the approaches taken by top funders of higher education in LMICs; and secondly, a selection of “crucial case” studies of four individual funders (Eckstein, 1975, Gerring, 2007), to try to capture changes that may not be explicit in publicly available documents. Broadly conceived, this study takes the form of a comparative case study, as our sample includes a subset of funders that support higher education in LMICs, which we treat as “cases” to more generally gain some insight into the multiplex, multi-scalar field of higher

education aid. Comparative case study is deemed well suited to research within such a complex multi-scalar social field in which “social actors, with diverse motives, intentions, and levels of influence work... [to] produce the social and cultural worlds in which they live” (Bartlett and Vavrus, 2017, p. 1). Nonetheless, we acknowledge that the diversity of the set of actors may restrict some elements of comparison and generalisability, and thus qualify our interpretation of our findings with this in mind.

The first ‘mapping’ phase of the study aimed to profile the top donors to higher education, in terms of our main dimensions of interest, i.e. donor rationales, roles, conceptualisation of higher education support, and modalities of support. In this phase, we focused our analysis on the top 15 donors to higher education in the period 2011–2020 and employed documentary analysis. Below we describe in detail the sampling of these top funders, as well as the specific application of documentary analysis to this phase.

The second component of the study focused on four selected crucial cases, each representing one of four initially categorised donor actor ‘types’: multilateral, Development Assistance Committee (DAC) bilateral, non-DAC bilateral, and private (organisation). This classification functioned as an early means of categorising the sample of top donors prior to document analysis or thematic coding. A combined approach of key informant interviews and document analysis allowed us to review published discourse, while also benefiting from an insider view of what changes there might be in donor engagement in terms of roles, rationales for support, modalities of support, or conceptualisations of support to higher education in the past 10–15 years.

2.1. Sampling

We selected 15 top funders of higher education in LMICs based on data on official development assistance and private development finance published in the OECD CRS Aid Activity database.² The OECD DAC currently comprises 32 member countries, with candidacy for future members assessed based on whether “appropriate” development strategies, policies, and a performance evaluation system exist, and an acceptable level of “effort” can be measured (e.g. via a certain ratio of ODA to Gross National Income (GNI), or an ODA volume above USD 100 million) (OECD, n.d.). (In reality, of course, OECD accession and DAC membership are much more of a political calculation than such technical requirements suggest (Lawson, 2013; Tüyoğlu, 2021)). Although OECD DAC member countries are better represented within the CRS database than non-DAC countries, a number of non-DAC countries selectively report data to the CRS, as do certain private sector organisations and foundations with critical capacity (Lawson, 2013).

As detailed by Rensimer and McCowan (2023), empirical reliance on data from the OECD CRS may be problematic if the data are treated as unqualifiedly representative of global aid flows to higher education. There are a range of methodological weaknesses of the CRS data, including (i) how different kinds of funding (and by which actors) are counted (and not counted) as ‘official’ in ODA measurements, (ii) the problem of international scholarship funding (counted within ODA) that effectively supports donor countries’ higher education systems in many instances, and (iii) technical accuracy and consistency within and across donor reporting resulting in misrepresentation and variation in the way data are categorised, thus limiting comparability. Further, some flows of funding to higher education in LMICs are known to exist but remain unreported and obscure, for instance, from Russia, China, and India (Rensimer and McCowan, 2023). However, despite these significant limitations, the OECD CRS database remains at present the most authoritative international data source for bilateral and multilateral aid flows. On balance, we felt confident in our use of the database for the

purposes of this study (i.e. not to paint a full picture of all aid flows to higher education but to identify and highlight some of the diversity that exists within this sector).

Sampling of ‘top funders’ took place in two stages. First, we looked at the aggregate aid data (Purpose Code 11420: Higher Education) for the period 2011–2020 to identify the top 15 funders of higher education to LMICs (see Table 1 below).³

However, we determined that this listing would not fulfil our objectives, as our primary concern was with funding flows that support higher education systems *within* recipient countries. As seen in the third column of Table 1, many of these organisations almost exclusively fund scholarships for residents of LMICs to study at institutions in the Global North. As this type of funding is ultimately absorbed by host country institutions, it is not an effective indicator of aid flows in support of higher education based in low-income contexts. Fortunately, the CRS distinguishes between assistance classified as “Scholarships/training in donor country” and other types of aid that flow to and remain in LMICs. CRS classifications, including “Other technical assistance” and “Project-type interventions”, do not exclude all international scholarships to the donor country, but do enable a rough separation of these two domains of activity, making it possible to parse the data to highlight those actors that provide the highest level of funding to systems and institutions of higher education based within LMICs. We, therefore, looked into the top contributors of non-external-scholarship funding to higher education in LMICs between 2011 and 2020 and arrived at a rather different set of organisations, presented in Table 2.

At this stage, we attempted to classify individual funders by donor ‘type’, with the theoretical assumption that there would be certain similarities that could be identified within particular groups of donors in terms of how and why changes in funding strategy have occurred. We then selected four crucial cases for the second phase of our analysis - the top donor from each of the four “types” listed in the table (i.e. the World

Table 1
Top 15 funders to higher education in LMICs, 2011–2020 combined.

Funder	Total HE aid (2011–2020)	Scholarship aid as % of total aid from donor ^a
Germany	\$15,886 mil	90 %
France	\$10,485 mil	96 %
Japan	\$3339 mil	65 %
EU Institutions	\$2401 mil	47 %
World Bank	\$2198 mil	0 %
USA	\$1690 mil	0 %
Austria	\$1432 mil	97 %
United Kingdom	\$1216 mil	70 %
Netherlands	\$898 mil	50 %
Türkiye	\$831 mil	50 %
South Korea	\$734 mil	59 %
MasterCard Foundation	\$726 mil	47 %
Poland	\$676 mil	100 %
Saudi Arabia	\$618 mil	97 %
Belgium	\$602 mil	27 %

^a We must acknowledge that some of these figures are inaccurate and/or partial. As our study progressed, it became clear that some of these percentages are imprecise. In the case of the US, for example, we learned during our interview with USAID personnel that USAID’s accounting and reporting method does not distinguish scholarship from non-scholarship aid. We also learned that some US scholarships are funded through other agencies and are not considered part of official ODA support (e.g. the Fulbright Program, funded through the Department of State). It is therefore not accurate that the US does not fund scholarships, as the “0 %” figure in our table suggests.

³ We determined that aggregate data over a defined period would be a more reliable measure of funding support, given that bilateral funding, in particular, can vary significantly year-by-year, depending on national budget priorities.

² <https://stats.oecd.org/Index.aspx?DataSetCode=CRS1> (discontinued in late May 2024)

Table 2

Top 15 providers of non-scholarship funding to higher education in LMICs, 2011–2020 combined.

Funder	Total non-external scholarship funding	Donor “type”
World Bank	\$ 2198.3 mil	Multilateral
United States	\$ 1690.1 mil	DAC bilateral
Germany	\$ 1529.1 mil	DAC bilateral
EU Institutions	\$ 1270.1 mil	Multilateral
Japan	\$ 1153.1 mil	DAC bilateral
France	\$ 458.2 mil	DAC bilateral
Netherlands	\$ 447.8 mil	DAC bilateral
Belgium	\$ 437.4 mil	DAC bilateral
Türkiye	\$ 411.9 mil	Non-DAC bilateral
MasterCard Foundation	\$ 384.9 mil	Private organisation
United Kingdom	\$ 370.4 mil	DAC bilateral
African Development Fund	\$ 325.3 mil	Multilateral
Korea	\$ 304.4 mil	DAC bilateral
Norway	\$ 252.7 mil	DAC bilateral
United Arab Emirates	\$ 163.3 mil	Non-DAC bilateral

Bank; the US Agency for International Development (USAID); the Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency (TIKA); and Mastercard Foundation) – in order to explore differences across these types.

2.2. Methods

For the first phase of the study, we sourced publicly available documents (reports, webpages, factsheets, brochures) from donors’ respective government or organisational websites. For the second phase of the study, elite key informant interviews were conducted with representatives from the four selected crucial cases. Document analysis methods included deductive and inductive coding, as well as identification of discursive phenomena, across both sets of data (i.e. documents and interview transcripts) during the crucial case analysis.

2.2.1. Documentary analysis

For the first phase of the study, documents were included if they were published within a 15-year period between 2008 and 2023 and if they included a content focus on funding flows to higher education in LMICs (if available), or more generally on education funding flows, or on broader development assistance (including education and/or higher education). For most donors, it was feasible to review all accessible documents that fell within the selection parameters. However, for some with a larger set of potentially relevant documents (e.g. the World Bank), a few were selected that were deemed to be strongly representative of the wider set of publications (as suggested by Emmel, 2013).

One important thing to highlight, in terms of the documents selected, is that we tried to review the published discourse of all relevant units related to a particular donor. This was particularly important in reference to bilateral assistance. In many donor governments, more than one unit is involved in support for higher education overseas (for instance, both GIZ, the Corporation for International Cooperation, and BMZ, the Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development, in Germany; and both Nuffic and the Ministry for Foreign Affairs in the Netherlands). We reviewed documents across all potentially relevant units in order to analyse the range of discourses that might exist.

The final list of documents analysed in this study are listed in [Supplementary Table 1](#). Our document analysis followed a three-stage hybrid inductive-deductive coding process (as suggested by Fereday and Muir-Cochrane (2006), and Blommaert (2005)).

2.2.2. Key informant interviews

Supplementing the documentary analysis with elite key informant interviews, we conducted four 30- to 60-minute interviews with one representative per funder; these were conducted remotely via Zoom.

These took the form of semi-structured conversations with “experts on the topic in question,” who “command a position of authority or privilege, often having some influence on decision making,” (Wicker and Connelly, 2014, n.p.). This strategy provided the flexibility of response from the informant as well as the potential to enter into the issues at hand in some depth (Peabody et al., 1990).

2.2.3. Data integration

Data from the two phases were combined prior to the final comparative analysis. The findings outlined in the final section of this paper rely primarily on the comparative document analysis but are also supplemented with key themes arising from the interview data.

2.3. Findings

When taken as a whole, the findings from our analysis highlight the importance of recognising the huge diversity that exists within the higher education funding landscape in low- and middle-income countries. Although trends can certainly be identified across and within donor ‘types’, there is a substantial amount of variation in our sample, in terms of the way(s) in which funding and donor roles are understood, the rationales for supporting higher education outside of domestic borders, and the approaches/modalities preferred. In this section, we present our findings in these main thematic categories, which structured our enquiry.

2.3.1. Donors’ conceptualisations of their roles

In terms of donor conceptualisation of their work and role, the first major finding is that the concept and language of ‘aid’ to higher education has clearly fallen out of favour. None of the funders in our sample referred to their work in higher education as ‘aid’, except for an indirect reference by the UK, which does have an overarching “Aid Strategy” from 2015 that includes support to higher education [UK Department for Education, UK Department for International Trade, 2019].⁴ In fact, some donors (e.g. Belgium, South Korea) explicitly contrast their current approach with older ‘aid’-focused approaches, stating that, “Development cooperation has nothing to do with the paternalistic ‘aid logic’ of the past” [VLIR-UOS (Belgium), 2020] and “[Developing countries are not] recipients of ‘aid’ [but] essential economic and political partners” (Korea-Official Development Assistance, 2022). Instead, all 15 sampled funders consistently use the language of “capacity development” and/or “technical assistance” when describing their work in the higher education sector. This trend is perhaps unsurprising, given the focus over the past 20 years on moving away from more traditional structures of ‘aid’ to the Global South, but it is striking in its breadth and consistency within our sample.

In addition to terms like “capacity development” and “technical assistance”, language related to “partnership” and “mutuality” can also be identified across all of the cases. However, the specifics of what this might entail differs quite dramatically. First, there are big differences, in terms of who (or what) the donor references as a partner. All of the multilaterals in the sample, for example, reference national governments as partners. Bilaterals, however, vary in this regard, with some referencing governments and others talking primarily about institutional partnerships (e.g. universities). The one private foundation in our sample partners only with institutions, although this category can include civil society organisations and non-profits, in addition to higher education institutions. The level of emphasis on mutuality and equality within the partnership also varies significantly, with some donors clearly expressing that they see themselves as “leaders” and/or “advisors” or “trainers” (a conceptualisation that implies that one partner in the partnership has more expertise than the other), while others

⁴ All documentary data are cited in square brackets and detailed in [Supplementary Table 1](#).

emphasise equality and shared experience. There was no consistency in these findings by donor ‘type’. However, the language of “leadership” or “advice” within partnership can be identified in the documentation of many of the bilaterals in our sample. USAID and all of the Western European donors in our sample (e.g. Germany, Belgium, France and the UK) all refer to themselves as leaders, advisors and/or trainers of higher education colleagues in the Global South. Japan, South Korea, Türkiye and the UAE, in notable contrast, talk about their role as being developmental “models” and/or “bridges” (in the case of South Korea and Türkiye) between less-resourced contexts and the rest of the world, complicating categorical distinctions between DAC and non-DAC bilateral donors in the sample. The multilateral organisations also tend to conceptualise their role as one of leadership, although the European Union does also refer to themselves as a “model”, at least in terms of modelling regional integration/harmonisation within the higher education sector.

Finally, further to the language of partnership, “cooperation” is used by all of the funders in the sample, aside from the Mastercard Foundation. Again, the specifics vary, in terms of with whom or what a particular donor cooperates, but the concept of working collaboratively with other donors is certainly an important and identifiable theme across all of the governmental donors in the sample. All 14 explicitly reference the SDGs and also clearly state that they work collaboratively with other multilaterals and bilaterals operating in the sector. Some also explicitly reference partnership with the private sector (e.g. the UK, Germany, the African Development Bank), although this is not universal (Belgium, in fact, explicitly expresses scepticism about private sector involvement in the higher education sector). The clear outlier in this regard is the Mastercard Foundation, which is very explicit about its operational independence from other donors working in higher education.

When taken as a whole, these findings indicate that there does appear to have been a change in discourse, with new language that recasts asymmetrical relations as ‘partnerships’ between equals. This discursive shift is strongly evident in the documents and was also corroborated in interviews, described as being a result of broader normative changes in the ‘aid’ landscape following the Paris Declaration on Aid Effectiveness (OECD, 2005) and the Accra Agenda for Action (OECD, 2008). It is clear from the data, however, that the extent to which these rhetorical changes have actually restructured donors’ operational approaches with respect to aid coordination is inconsistent across the sample, even within particular categories or types.

2.3.2. Donors’ rationales for supporting higher education

Donor rationales for providing financial support to higher education systems in the Global South are also distinctive. All funders express what might be termed ‘developmental’ rationales; however, their conceptualisation of development varies, with some donors (e.g. Germany, Mastercard) exclusively framing development in terms of the individuals who might benefit from higher education and other donors talking more expansively about the various ways in which higher education contributes to development at both the individual and the societal level. These differences do not map in any systematic way across donor types, with the exception of the multilateral organisations, which uniquely frame development in regional terms.

However, underneath this umbrella rationale are some key differences by donor type. Most obviously, most of the bilateral organisations in the sample complement developmental rationales with political rationales for engaging in support for higher education, but with considerable diversity in the kinds of political rationales employed. These rationales sometimes focus explicitly on the national interest (e.g. the UK’s aid strategy tagline, “Tackling global challenges in the national interest” [UK Department for Education, UK Department for International Trade, 2019], or “For the World, For the Netherlands” [Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Netherlands), 2018]). These broad-level rationales guiding foreign policy are also elaborated within the higher education

strategy of these two contexts. Nuffic (Netherlands) explicitly states that they aim to “promote the full scope of the Dutch higher education system abroad...[and] contribute to the formulation of a strategy to attract talent from abroad to the Dutch labour market” (Nuffic, 2023), while the UK’s International Education Strategy (UK Department for International Trade & Department for Education, 2021) states an objective of “grow [ing] export opportunities” and its Education Policy promotes “linkages between UK universities and those in the South” in order to “project UK influence and strengthen UK trade and investment opportunities” (UK Department for International Development, 2018). Slightly ‘softer’ political rationales are also evident, for example, in the case of Japan, which, in addition to “contribut[ing] to industrial development and employment promotion”, supports higher education in the Global South in order to develop “pro-Japan leaders” and “pro-Japanese intellectuals with good knowledge of Japan” (Japan International Cooperation Agency, 2024).

In the case of the two non-DAC bilaterals, as well as South Korea and Japan, it is possible to identify a set of rationales linked to the international perception of their roles and their global stature. For example, in a document entitled “Korea’s enhanced global standing as a middle-power donor country”, Korea’s position as chair in a network of donor countries is understood as a means of “expand[ing] Korea’s influence...while playing a responsible and fair role in global development cooperation, and to raise Korea’s standing on the global stage” (Korea-Official Development Assistance, 2022). Similarly, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Türkiye notes its focus on “accentuat[ing] the country’s growing role in global cooperation”. These rationales are also ‘political’ but in quite a different sense (Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2022).

The two non-DAC bilateral donors in the sample uniquely express what could be termed ‘cultural’ rationales for engaging in support for higher education. These rationales are also political, but extend beyond strictly national interest in economic terms. TİKA in Türkiye, for example, aims to “[carry] common history and cultural heritage” (Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency, 2019) through its interventions by prioritizing work with countries that share a common religious and cultural background. The UAE also references its “Arab-Islamic heritage” (United Arab Emirates Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation, 2017) as an important rationale for its work outside its borders, including in the higher education sector.

Finally, it is possible to identify rationales for engaging in support for higher education which are more about justifying higher education as a relevant sector to support as an enabler of broader development goals, over other levels of education or any other sector, e.g. “As recipient, partner and implementer of USAID funding, higher education is central for the missions of USAID” (USAID, 2019) or “Higher education...underpin[s] education, health and nutrition service provision by training the professionals needed to run the system” (UK Department for International Development, 2018). This framing of such a rationale was supported by two of our elite interviews in which interviewees observed feeling pressure within their organisations to justify support for higher education, given competing demands on donor funding and entrenched views of higher education as a private, rather than a public, good. It appears, therefore, that this category of rationale might be focused more on internal than external audiences, calling our attention to the spectrum of potential audiences that such documents are intended to reach. Clearly, all donors need to engage in a process of explaining their rationales and approaches through their policy documents and other public-facing communications. However, we identified no discernible pattern by donor type, aside from bilateral agencies’ explicit statement of their political rationales, presumably to justify their spending to tax-paying domestic audiences.

Seen in these distinct ways, the rationales identified in our sample problematise conventional classifications by donor type. Just as was the case with donors’ selective use of mutuality discourses to conceptualise their roles, their rationales clustered in unexpected ways in our sample. Again, rather than the assumed cohesiveness of DAC donor discourse on

one hand, and non-DAC discourse on the other, the discourses of Japan and Korea more closely matched those of the non-DAC bilaterals in our sample.

2.3.3. Donors' preferred modalities and approaches to support

Our analysis also identified significant diversity in the modalities of support and approaches taken by the funders in our sample. Higher education is supported in myriad ways - across the funding landscape as a whole but also within the portfolios of individual organisations. Some of these differences do map across donor type. The multilateral donors in our sample, for instance, support a greater variety of modalities than do any of the bilaterals and are more likely to focus their work at the level of the system or even the region, rather than at the institutional level. However, as was the case in our analysis of the discourse of partnership, much of the existing diversity appears *within* respective donor types, particularly in terms of the bilateral organisations in the sample.

The funding of international scholarships by bilateral donors (DAC and non-DAC) was a constant in our sample. However, there are important nuances, in terms of how scholarships are structured and how they are discussed. Many bilaterals (e.g. Germany, France, Netherlands, Norway, UK) support traditional scholarship models, whereby students from the Global South are funded to complete their studies in the donor agency country. Others offer very different kinds of scholarships, e.g. Japan's regionally focused scholarships (whereby students are funded to study at other regional universities, rather than in Japanese institutions). The focus can also vary, in terms of the level of study funded, with some donors emphasising postgraduate study in fields not available in the Global South, an approach which has very different implications from funding undergraduate students who would have the option to study the same subject in their home context. The rationale for funding scholarships also varies significantly, with some programs expressing clear developmental rationales (e.g. the development of "future leaders in socio-economic development and policymaking in the respective country" (Japan International Cooperation Agency, 2024), while others emphasise the domestic benefits for those in the donor country (e.g. the value of having students from the Global South, in terms of donor country internationalisation efforts - as discussed by NORPART in Norway (Nordhagen et al, 2020).

Collaborative research and/or other kinds of partnerships between higher education institutions in the donor and recipient countries are also identifiable as a typical approach, this time across all DAC donors (including Korea and Japan) but not the two non-DAC donors in the sample. Once again, the specifics of these arrangements differ dramatically in terms of the disciplines supported (Korea, for example, funds primarily STEM-focused collaborations, while Norway explicitly prioritises support for the humanities), as well as the objectives and arrangements of the partnerships.

2.4. Drivers of change

Our final area of inquiry was to identify the key drivers of any identified change in the discourses (and, potentially, programmatic choices) of the donors in our sample. Ultimately, we do not have sufficient evidence to make any strong statements on this topic, as we were only able to probe this question within the key informant interviews (and are, therefore, limited to only considering data from four of the 15 funders). However, the data we do have points to some interesting exploratory findings. First, all four of the key informant interviews focused primarily on internal drivers of change. Specifically, all of the interviewees mentioned using (or commissioning) their own internal research teams to conduct analysis to support the development of their strategic plans, and all highlighted the important roles that particular individuals have played in driving changes in policy, whether as organisational leaders (in the case of the private organisation) or as leaders of individual units responsible for higher education within larger institutional structures (in the case of the other three funders). Second,

although all of the interviewees also acknowledged external drivers of change, the specific external driver(s) varied by donor 'type', with the multilateral organisation highlighting the influence of recipient country governments, the two bilaterals highlighting the role of political priorities, and the private donor highlighting the influence of institutional partners in country. International agreements related to discourse also appear to have had an impact, although not to the same degree across donors. Our interviewees at both the World Bank and USAID stressed that support to higher education is no longer discussed in the language of 'aid', implying that this is a change from previous practice. Our interviewees in Türkiye and at MasterCard Foundation, in contrast, suggested that their organisations would never have understood support through a lens of 'aid'.

2.5. Discussion

We summarise our results, classified in terms of the actions of different donor 'types', in Table 3 (below).

From the outset, our assumption was that donor "types" would respond in different ways to the changes in the aid landscape we set out to analyse. In certain limited ways, our data supported this assumption. Political rationales for supporting higher education in lower-income contexts, for example, were only present in the discourse of bilateral organisations. However, as a whole, the 'types' did not have much explanatory power. Some of the trends that we identified were found across all donor 'types' in the sample, e.g. shared language around capacity development and partnership, as opposed to aid, and a focus on developmental rationales for support to higher education. Others could only be identified in terms of certain groups of donors within a particular 'type'. The bilateral organisations are the most diverse in this regard. Our *a priori* assumption that DAC and non-DAC bilaterals would behave differently generally did not hold. Instead, we could identify a tendency for Japan and Korea to use discourse more in line with the non-DAC donors in our sample than with other DAC donors. However, there were limits to this grouping, as Japan and Korea more closely resemble other DAC donors when it comes to collaboration and partnership between higher education institutions.

3. Conclusions and implications

Collectively, our analysis of the documentary data identifies a clear linguistic shift in the ways that donor organisations at least publicly conceive their roles. Accordingly, funding practices are no longer principled on sending aid, nor do they explicitly sustain discourses of 'helping' asymmetrically positioned 'recipients' of aid under conditions of a DAC-centric world order. The donor landscape has broadened and diversified, and the language used to conceptualise donors' roles appears to have shifted concordantly. Across this landscape is the universal framing of donor agencies as providing support which facilitates mutual benefit and partnership – and which is most effective when implemented in a spirit of cooperation. In the contemporary language of international support to higher education, it seems, traditional donors have embraced this blurring of their relationships with key 'partner' countries, both in alignment with post-Paris Declaration aid discourse, and in response to the decline of US hegemony and the rise of new influential actors in the aid space.

In understanding these discursive dynamics, it is important to bear in mind the different audiences being addressed by the statements and publications of international organisations. In the first place, there are external audiences, including other international development agencies but also recipient countries, likely to expect a framing of collaborative, horizontal and mutually beneficial relationships. In the case of bilaterals, there is also the national community of citizens whose taxes are being allocated, and which, in light of recent populist movements, may need persuading that overseas aid is a justified destination of their earnings. Yet there are also audiences internal to the organisation itself,

Table 3
Summary of key findings by donor ‘type’.

		DAC bilateral (excluding Japan and Korea)	Japan and Korea	Non-DAC bilateral	Multilateral	Private organisation
Conceptualisation of roles	<i>Language</i>	Abandonment or rejection of ‘aid’; adoption of “capacity development”, “technical assistance”, “partnership” and “mutuality”	Broadly position themselves as purveyors of “leadership” or “advice” and training	Position themselves as development “models” and “bridges”	All position themselves as “leaders”; EU also as “model” (with respect to system-wise harmonisation)	Broadly position themselves as purveyors of “leadership” or “advice” and training
	<i>Coordination</i>	Partnership varies: some with national governments, some with universities			Partnership strictly with national governments	Partnership with institutions (including universities, NGOs and civil society organisations)
		Cooperation with other donors within and across donor types; explicit reference to SDGs				Explicit operational independence from other donors
Rationale	<i>Developmental</i>	All articulate developmental rationales, although these vary in specific focus by individual donor				
	<i>Political</i>	Political with economic self-interest	Political with interest in expanding influence and reach	N/A	N/A	N/A
Approaches	<i>Other</i>	N/A	N/A	Cultural	N/A	N/A
	<i>Individual scholarships</i>	Scholarships for study in donor country; levels of study vary by donor	Mix of scholarships for study in donor country and scholarships for study elsewhere in donor region	Mix of scholarships for study in donor country and scholarships for study elsewhere in donor region	N/A	Scholarships for study within recipient region
	<i>Collaborative research and/or partnerships between HEIs in donor and recipient countries</i>	Collaborative research and/or partnership between HE institutions typical		Collaborative research and/or partnership between HE institutions not identifiable	N/A	N/A
Drivers of change	<i>Internal</i>	Internal/commissioned research; individual leadership				
	<i>External</i>	National political priorities	N/A (not represented in interview phase)	National political priorities	Recipient government priorities	Institutional partner priorities

potentially with competing interests. In some cases expenditure on higher education has to be justified in relation to basic education (the former has often been framed as a luxury in light of the pressing needs for universalising primary education and basic skills), and in others there may need to be advocacy for the whole sector of education in relation to other foci such as health, agriculture or governance. Multiplicity of authorship further complicates the picture, e.g. in bilateral cases where more than one unit is involved in policy related to higher education support. Particular types of units (i.e. traditional international cooperation units, more politically or economically-oriented units, etc) often have distinct audiences, which may be more or less receptive to particular rationales and/or conceptualisations of support.

At the same time, it appears that these discursive shifts are often at odds with donor approaches in practice, which, particularly among bilaterals, continue to be dominated by self-serving practices including international scholarships and institutional partnerships. Within these practices, explicit aims of projecting leadership or influence through donor soft power and knowledge diplomacy challenge the notion that a transformative shift has occurred in the relationship between donors and recipients. The disconnection between ideals of ‘shared prosperity’ and national self-interest (Mawdsley et al., 2018) observed in donor country internationalisation strategies is a particularly striking and consistent feature of bilateral donors, both new and traditional, with higher education aid articulated and justified as much through its political and economic ends as through its developmental aspirations. Our data do indicate some important variations by donor type, including greater use of language suggesting parity between new donors and their partners, as well as the prevalence of other stated rationales which attend to cultural engagement. On the whole, however, bilateral donors old and new are aligned in their need to rationalise their support for higher education systems and institutions beyond their national borders

in ways that are seen as palatable by their home constituencies.

While we are limited in our ability to comment on the potential for multilateral and private organisations to disrupt these more ‘self-serving’ mechanisms, given that our design included only three multilaterals and one private donor, we can observe a wider range of modalities and approaches implemented by non-bilateral donors in our sample. It may be, therefore, that organisations which are free from the need to justify their funding to a particular national audience can be more innovative and, potentially, responsive to the needs of recipient contexts. However, this can also not be assumed, as hierarchical language, implying power imbalances between donor and recipient, can still be identified in all of the multilateral organisations included in our sample, even if the discourse has moved away from more obviously power-dominant terms such as ‘aid’. In the case of the one private organisation in our sample, we can also identify a distinct lack of interest in cooperation with other donors or even recipient country governments, implying that broader attempts to change the ‘effectiveness’ of aid have not necessarily had any influence on the approaches taken by private actors. The implications of this lack of alignment between global development norms and private activities are significant, particularly given the increasing influence of private funding in the higher education sector.

In assessing these dynamics, it is important not to assume a simple correspondence between what is said and what is done, with the latter necessarily flowing from the former. Indeed, our discussions with organisational representatives revealed that donor discourse and actions are often not linearly related. In some cases, changes in concrete practices may be the logical consequence of written policies and principles, but in others the statements are retrospective justifications of what is already happening. Disparities between the two are sometimes the result of implementation gaps and constraints in the field, or the result of time

lag. They can also be deliberate, providing ‘window dressing’ for continuing conventional practice. These complexities require further research before we can fully understand how shifts in language about international aid to higher education may or may not translate into shifts in practice.

Other areas in need of research have been exposed by this largely exploratory study. First, further analyses are needed on the flows of aid funds to higher education, addressing gaps and anomalies in our current datasets (as identified in Rensimer and McCowan, 2023). Second, in-depth qualitative studies are needed on the work of different donor organisations and on recipient countries and organisations, assessing not only motivations and relationships but also impacts. In particular, focus is needed on new actors such as China and India, whose role is widely acknowledged but about which there is a significant lack of documented information. The process of gradual shifting from recipient to donor evident in these countries is an important dimension for further investigation.

Taken as a whole, the findings from this study offer a timely reflection on not only development actors’ roles in funding higher education in LMICs, but also the role of higher education itself as a strategic vehicle for achieving the SDGs (McCowan, 2019) and how donors position higher education within their broader development agendas and aid portfolios. Aid has reached an inflection point, with the amalgamation of development, trade interests, and geopolitical influence, illustrated in recent mergers of respective government offices in the UK, Australia, Canada, and elsewhere (Gulrajani, 2018). We see the contradictions (in discourse) and continuities (in donor practices, including those of new donors) as reflective of the tensions in the shift to a multiplex global order (Acharya, 2017), where higher education is increasingly instrumentalised as a tool of epistemic and geopolitical struggles. Knowledge for development, while popularly framed as an apolitical challenge for achieving technocratic targets like the SDGs, clearly enters the ‘political’ sphere where such knowledge is mobilised through international exchange and diplomacy. In this regard, the approaches and rationales for higher education funding observed in our data fall squarely into the ‘retroliberal’ aid paradigm, combining neoliberal rationales with state-led strategies for steering global development and countering the influence of rising donors (Murray and Overton, 2016). Our analysis highlights the diversity of specific approaches taken by individual donors, reminding us that it is unhelpful to assume that all support for higher education looks the same, regardless of a particular donor’s structure or context. Acknowledging that the increasingly ‘multiplex’ global order has introduced some diversity in a sector long dominated by traditional structures and hierarchies is an important recognition that innovation is at least being attempted by many working within the sector. At the same time, the evidence from this study highlights broad conformity to global trends in higher education, raising critical questions of the role of higher education systems in zero-sum geopolitics and competition over knowledge-based development agendas.

Author statement

We the undersigned declare that this manuscript is original, has not been published before and is not currently being considered for publication elsewhere. We confirm that the manuscript has been read and approved by all named authors and that there are no other persons who satisfied the criteria for authorship but are not listed. We further confirm that the order of authors listed in the manuscript has been approved by all of us. We understand that the Corresponding Author is the sole contact for the Editorial process. He/she is responsible for communicating with the other authors about progress, submissions of revisions and final approval of proofs

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Tessa DeLaquil: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft,

Data curation, Conceptualization. **Rebecca Schendel:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Tristan McCowan:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Conceptualization. **Lee Rensimer:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Appendix A. Supporting information

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